

LIFE-STUDY OF EPHESIANS
MESSAGE FORTY-ONE
THE WAY TO BE PERFECTED
(con,t)

IN THE CHURCH AND UNDER THE MINISTRY

The practice of today's Christianity is not the Lord's way according to the New Testament. In Christianity seminaries are established to train people to serve the Lord. But those educated in the seminaries are not perfected according to God's New Testament economy. The genuine perfection of the saints must be in the church and under the ministry. Today the Lord's ministry is criticized, slandered, and scorned. If the eyes of the believers are opened, they will see what the ministry is and where it is today. In the church the ministry is needed to perfect the saints unto the work of ministry, unto the building up of the Body of Christ.

I am very concerned that little has actually been accomplished among us to perfect the saints unto the work of ministry. How much we have been under the influence of degraded Christianity! Many Christians today care mainly for the preaching of the gospel and somewhat for the teaching of the Bible. We all need to see clearly that today the Lord is doing one work—to perfect all the saints until we all arrive. We have seen that in Ephesians 4 Paul did not place himself in a separate category. Rather, he included himself with all the saints. We all, including Paul, need to hold the truth and grow up into Christ until we arrive at a full-grown man.

In these days I bear a very heavy burden concerning the perfecting of the saints. This burden cannot be discharged until I see that all the saints are able to do the same kind of [352] work as was done by the early apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers. I do not care merely to be a preacher or a teacher of the Bible. I desire to be perfected and to perfect others unto the building up of the Body of Christ.

LIFE AND FUNCTION

In order to be perfected, we must pay attention to life and to function. The way to be perfected is to grow in life and to become skillful in function. The Greek word rendered "perfecting" here also means completing, equipping, furnishing. To perfect a saint is to complete him, to equip him, and to furnish him. Only by growing in life can we be completed. Not until we become mature will we be completed. For example, a child of five is not a full-grown person. As long as, spiritually speaking, we remain underage, we shall not be complete. Mothers perfect their children by feeding them. Furthermore, parents equip their children and furnish them by training them to behave and to speak in a certain way. Thus, children are perfected by feeding and by training. The same is true with respect to perfecting the saints according to God's economy. The saints need to be fed and they need to be trained so that they may function with the proper skill.

Once when I was visiting a certain place which was regarded as being rather spiritual, I was asked why we conduct trainings in the Lord's recovery. I replied that as human beings we need to grow and we need also to learn. If we do not grow, we shall not have the stature required to do certain things. If we do not learn, we shall be "barbarians." For example, if a child is not taught to eat properly with the necessary utensils, he will be "wild" and unruly at the table. Do not think that as long as a person is spiritual in life, he requires no training. No, in spiritual things, as in physical things, there is the need of training. In spiritual things we need the maturity, the growth in life, and we also need the skill. The maturity comes from growth, and the skill comes from training. Therefore, in order to perfect the saints, we [353] need to feed them with spiritual food that they may grow, and we also need to train them to develop certain skills.

THE NEED FOR THOROUGH TRAINING

To the present moment, I have not yet discharged my burden in the matter of training. We need to be trained for the practice of the church life. This means that the training should enrich and uplift our practice of the church life. Although the help given to the saints thus far is far from adequate, we cannot deny the fact that since coming into the Lord's recovery many saints have undergone some training. This is evident as we listen to them testify or pray in the meetings. However, the need remains for more thorough and complete training. My burden is that after a period of time, perhaps after three or four years, virtually all the saints in the Lord's recovery in this country will have been adequately trained.

To be trained is to have the rich supply of Christ ministered to us that we may grow, and it is to be equipped that we may be skillful in speaking, in contacting new ones, in shepherding, and in preaching and teaching. Do not say that you cannot speak because you are not a talented speaker. We all are able to speak for the Lord.

THE LORD'S WAY

Once the saints have been perfected, then wherever they go, they will be apostles, the ones sent to that place. They will also be prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers. To perfect the saints to be such gifts to the Body is the Lord's way. If we do not follow this way, the Lord will not be able to get what He desires. How we thank Him that, in His mercy, He has shown us His way!

We have seen that in 4:13-15 Paul did not exclude himself. Rather, he said, "Until we all arrive...that we may be no longer babes...but holding to truth in love, we may grow up into Him in all things...." None of us should think that we have already been perfected. On the contrary, we all need more life supply and more training. If we are willing to grow [354] and to be trained, then we shall not repeat the history of Christianity. If we are faithful to practice what the Lord shows us, the Lord will have a way among us. The Lord's way has never changed. His way is to perfect the saints to do the work of ministry for the building up of the Body of Christ. This is the way for the Lord to gain what He desires as the necessary preparation for His coming back.

LIFE-STUDY OF EPHESIANS MESSAGE FORTY-TWO ALL BUILDING MEMBERS WITHOUT RANK

Throughout the centuries Christians have held the natural concept that the church is merely a social organization. Actually the church is not an organization. As Paul says in his Epistles, the church is the Body of Christ. Our physical body, which is a picture of the mystical Body of Christ, is not an organization, but an organism. As an organism, it is altogether dependent upon life. When the life is gone, the body becomes a corpse, which could possibly be regarded as an organization.

AN ORDER OF FUNCTION, NOT OF RANK

The concept that the church is a social organization has caused a great deal of damage. In social organizations there is the need for certain members to be on the top, to be of the highest rank. In religion this may take the form of hierarchy. But there is no hierarchy in our physical body. No doubt, certain members are above others, but this is a matter of functional order, not of rank. For example, for the purpose of function, the nose is higher than the mouth. It would be absurd to say that the nose has a higher rank than the mouth has. In like manner, our fingers are below both our arms and shoulders. But this does not mean that the fingers have a lower rank. This is entirely a matter of order according to function. How could the fingers function if they were attached to the shoulders? Therefore, in the physical body, a picture of the living organism of the Body of Christ, there is no rank nor hierarchal order, but only order according to function.

In the past I have met some women who did not agree with Paul's word in Ephesians 5 about wives submitting to their husbands. Likewise, they could not accept Paul's word [356] in 1 Corinthians 11 about the man being the head of the woman. Under the influence of the modern concept of female emancipation, they questioned why the woman had to be under the man. I answered them by pointing to the arrangement of the members in our physical body. I tried to show them that this arrangement is not a matter of rank, but a matter of function. For example, the nose is in the right place for its particular function. The same is true of all the members of the body. However, the fact that the nose is higher than the mouth in functional order does not mean that it is of a higher rank than the mouth. To consider the matter of rank with respect to the Body of Christ is to be under the influence of the fallen human concept. Many troubles and problems have been caused by this very concept.

As we consider the apostles, prophets, and elders spoken of in the New Testament, we need to drop the natural concept. If we hold to our natural concept, we shall automatically think that the apostles, prophets, and elders have a higher rank. The concept of rank is altogether a natural concept, a concept foreign to the Scriptures. The apostles, prophets, and elders carry out certain functions, but fulfilling these functions does not place them on a level above the other saints. In the Body there are many members, and these members have different functions. Although there is a difference of function, there is no difference of rank. In an organism there is no consciousness of rank. If our shoulders could speak, they would say that they have never thought of having any rank in our body; they would say that they have never regarded themselves as higher than the other members.

Some of the elders have been rather proud of their position and have expected the saints to give place to them. Other brothers have been ambitious to become elders. There is no room for such ambition in the church life. If we know the Bible, we shall realize that an elder is a slave. The thought of rank must be purged away. The apostles and elders are not high officials. On the contrary, they are those who serve Christ to the churches and to the saints. [357]

THE PERFECTING OF THE SAINTS UNTO THE WORK OF MINISTRY

My burden in this message is to point out that all the saints should be building members. Ephesians 4:11 says, "And He gave some apostles, and some prophets, and some evangelists, and some shepherds and teachers." These gifted ones are not high officials with a special rank. Rather, they are given for the perfecting of the saints (v. 12). The saints need to be perfected, equipped, furnished, unto the work of ministry. This work of ministry is the building up of the Body of Christ. Because so many saints are not yet doing the work of ministry, they need the gifted ones mentioned in verse 11 to perfect them, to equip them, that they may be qualified to carry out the work of ministry for the building up of the Body of Christ. The perfecting or equipping is related both to growth in life and to training in certain skills.

The light on these verses has never been as bright and clear as it is today. We have seen that the work of ministry is simply the building up of the Body of Christ. This work should be carried out not only by the apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers, but by all the members. Hence, all the saints are building members. We are not only members who have been built up, but we are also members who build up the Body. Firstly, the apostles, prophets, evangelists, and shepherds and teachers perfect the saints. This means that they build up the saints. Then the perfected saints become the building members. In these days the saints are being perfected. But after another period of time I expect that the saints who are being perfected now will also become the building ones.